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God Is Love

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God Is Love

His very essence is self-giving, sacrificial love.

God Is Love (1 John 4:8, 16)

“The person who does not love does not know God, because God is love. ... And we have come to know and to believe the love that God has in us. God is love, and the one who resides in love resides in God, and God resides in him.” These verses do not merely say that God loves; they declare that love is who He is. Everything else Scripture reveals about His character flows from this reality.

The Gift of His Only Son (John 3:16)

“For this is the way God loved the world: He gave his one and only Son, so that everyone who believes in him will not perish but have eternal life.” This verse reveals the magnitude of God’s love: He gave what was most precious to Him—not for the deserving, but for a rebellious world—so that sinners might receive eternal life through Christ.

Christ’s Death for Sinners (Romans 5:8)

“But God demonstrates his own love for us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” At the very moment when humanity was in open rebellion against Him, God gave His Son to die in our place. This is the ultimate display of self-giving, sacrificial love that seeks the good of the undeserving.

Hosea’s Marriage as a Living Parable (Hosea 1–3)

God commanded the prophet Hosea to marry an unfaithful wife as a picture of His relationship with Israel. Despite repeated adultery, God instructed Hosea to pursue and redeem her. The Lord declared, “I will betroth you to me forever; I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy” (Hosea 2:19). This illustrates God’s relentless, covenant-keeping love that pursues and restores even the faithless.

The Prodigal Son and Our Adoption (Luke 15:11–32; Romans 8:15–16)

In Jesus’ parable, the father (representing God) watches for his wayward son, runs to meet him while he is still far off, embraces him, restores him fully, and celebrates with joy. This story portrays the eager, compassionate, and lavishly forgiving heart of

the Father toward every repentant sinner. Through the Spirit we are adopted as children of God and cry, “Abba, Father,” revealing the intimate, relational depth of His self-giving love.

Daily Impact

Love is not a mood God enters when we have finally become lovable. “God is love.” Before we believed, before we asked, while we were still sinners, He gave His Son. That truth first settles the heart. We are not trying to attract a reluctant God. We are answering a love already in motion—the Father who runs, the Husband who redeems the unfaithful, the Spirit who teaches us to say *Abba*. Then the same love begins to reshape the way we treat people. We cannot receive the cross and keep a closed fist. Daily this attribute calls us to stop earning what has been given, to forgive as we have been forgiven, and to seek another’s good at cost to ourselves. Love of this kind is not sentiment. It is holy self-giving, learned at the place where Christ died for the undeserving.

Because God is love, I will love and give as I have been loved by Him.

Questions for Personal Application

1. Where am I still trying to become worthy of a love that met me while I was a sinner?
2. Whom do I need to pursue with Hosea’s kind of loyalty—the person I would rather release than redeem?
3. How should the Father who runs toward the prodigal change the way I welcome a repentant person this week?
4. What would self-giving love look like in one costly place—time, pride, money, or forgiveness—because He first gave His Son?
5. Whom can I remind that they are not loved after they improve, but in Christ, while they are still in need?

Word Pictures of God’s Love

The Gift of the Son

Love is measured by what it spends. God did not send an explanation. He gave His only Son for a world that was not asking. This is the center. Every other picture of love must bow here.

The Father Who Runs

The son is still on the road, still unclean, still mid-sentence. The father does not wait for a finished apology. He runs, embraces, restores. Love moves first. Love is not dignity protecting itself. It is joy receiving the lost.

The Husband Who Buys Back the Unfaithful

Hosea does not illustrate a feeling. He enacts a covenant. Love goes after the one who left, pays the price, and speaks betrothal again. This is love that has been wounded and still binds itself.

Reflection

These pictures remind us that love is not God in a softer mood. It is God giving Himself. He spends the Son. He runs while we are still on the road. He buys back the unfaithful and speaks betrothal again. Because He is love, we stop trying to attract a reluctant heart. We receive what has already moved toward us. Then we learn its shape: costly giving, eager welcome, covenant pursuit of people we would rather release.

1. What have I been withholding that the Gift of the Son would spend—pride, pardon, time, or the better place at the table?
2. Whom am I still waiting to finish the speech, when the Father has already taught me to run?
3. Where is love asking me to pay a Hosea price—to go after someone who left, rather than to protect my dignity and be done?

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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